

known as personal video players, let you view video clipping/video films apart from listening to audio. These score over MP3 players in that they have a larger display screen and can support more formats than MP3 players. Like MP3 players, these may come in hard drive or flash memory versions. Good-quality branded MP4 players are priced between Rs 2000 and Rs 18,000.

MP4 players from Humx are available in screen sizes ranging from 7.1 cm (2.8 inches) to 7.6 cm (3 inches), with built-in capacity of 1 GB, 2 GB or 4 GB. There are four models in all: MP252, MP342, MP432 and MP522. All are MLC flash memory-based and support rechargeable Li-ion battery, 20 FM channels, numerous audio and video formats (MP3, WMA, WAV, DAT, VOB, MP4, MOV, ASF, ASX and WMV), e-book and game function. The MP252 and MP432 also support RM/RMVB, AVI, FLV, 3GP and MPG formats.

CD players with 'MP3' compatibility. Other than flash-memory and hard-disk portable players, many of today's portable CD players also let you play digital music saved on disks. But these don't support the copyright-protected formats from online music stores. Controls and displays are as good as in portable MP3 players, and

you can group songs on each disk according to artist, genre and other categories.

A CD, with its 650 to 800MB storage capacity (about 150 to 200 songs), can hold more than ten hours of MP3-format music at the standard CD-quality setting. You can create MP3 CDs using the proper software and your PC's CD burner.

Cell phones. An increasing number of phones have built-in MP3 players—some with controls and features that rival standalone players. Some cell-phone providers let subscribers download music over their networks. Song capacity is often determined by the size of the external memory card, as well as the phone manufacturer, carrier or music provider.

What to look for in an MP3 player?

Size, weight and design. Let's face it, aesthetics go a long way. Just like mobile phones, MP3 players have become fashion accessories. The player should also be lightweight, compact and easy to operate with one hand. Some MP3 players are so small that these can hang off a keychain, while others will barely fit in your hand.

Tomonori Moroda, division head, personal audio, Sony India, says that the smallest players are great for

workout routines, jogging or even clipping to a shirt lapel for everyday use. Larger MP3 players are fantastic for playing video and enjoying music, but these are typically much more expensive and can be considered niche products with far fewer accessories. Appearance aside, a player's design also goes hand in hand with its size and weight. This can vary a lot between devices, the lightest weighing around 20 gm.

Hard-disk players tend to be much heavier than their flash counterparts due to the weight of the hard disk and the larger battery required. Lightweight and sleek flash-memory-based players are the current style statement.

Whichever MP3 player you choose, make sure you'll be comfortable using the device. Look for a display that is easy to read. Also, the controls should be easily accessible.

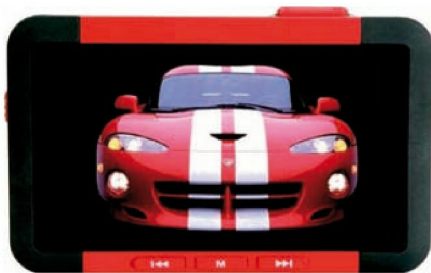
Audio format. MP3 (Moving Pictures Expert Group Audio Layer 3) is just one of the many formats you can play on digital audio players. It is a digital audio format encoded on computer from a source such as CD. The files are compressed but retain near-original sound quality. Most MP3 players can play one or more other compressed audio formats too, such as Advanced Audio Coding (AAC), Ogg Vorbis (OGG) and Microsoft's Windows Media Audio (WMA). Make sure that your player is compatible with MP3, WMA and AAC at least.

Here's how these audio formats differ:

WMA. A Windows Media Audio file is about half the size of an MP3 file, but offers similar sound quality.

If you want to fit as many songs as possible onto your audio player, look for WMA compatibility. A 60GB WMA-compatible MP3 player can store up to 30,000 songs in WMA format—or just 15,000 in MP3.

MP3Pro. It has better audio quality than MP3, but isn't widely popular among manufacturers.



Humx MP4 player